COURT OF MASTER SOMMELIERS Americas

INTRODUCTORY SOMMELIER

GRAPE VARIETY PROFILES

Grape Variety Profiles
A Guide for Students New to Wine

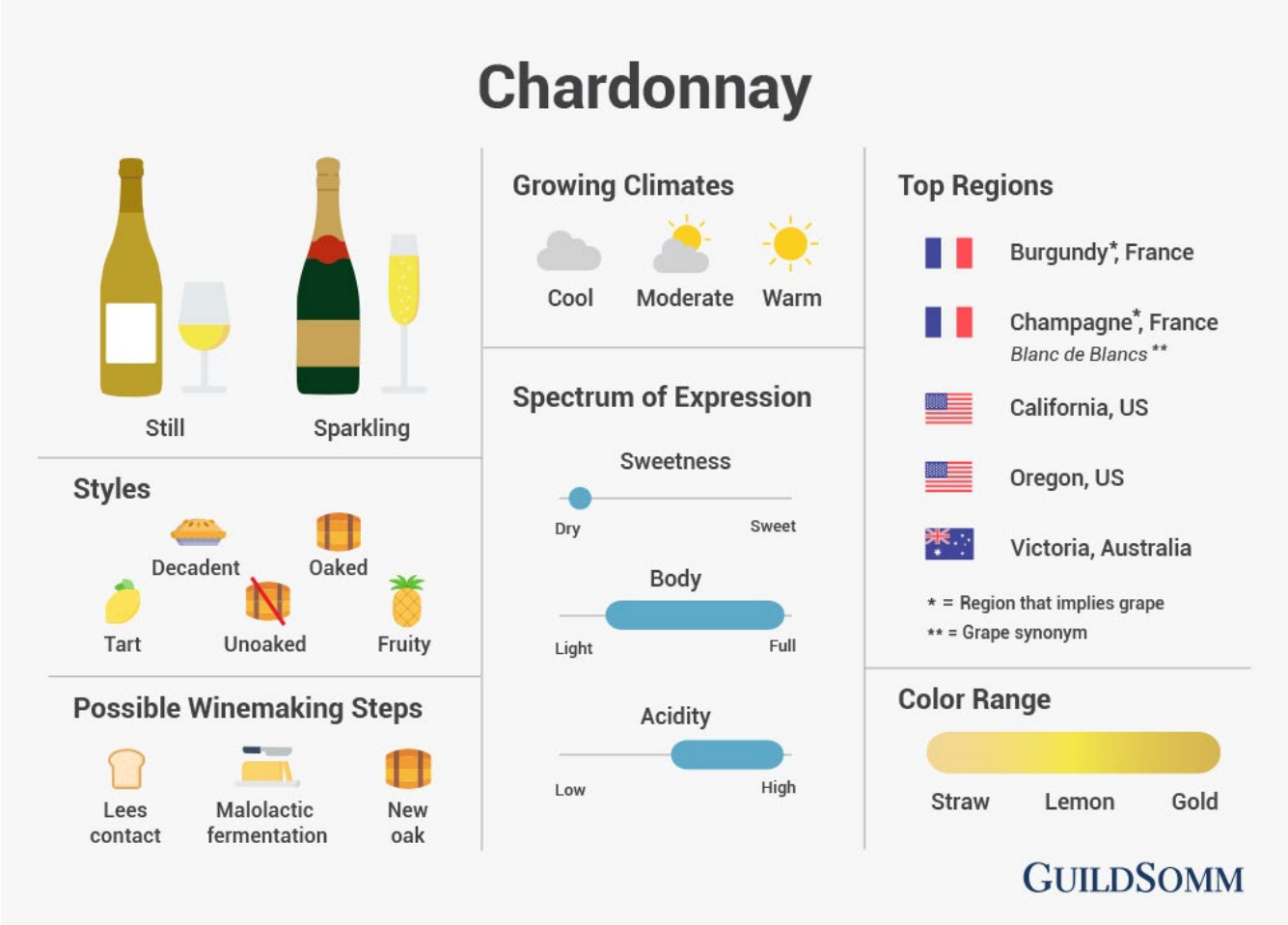
These grape variety profiles are designed to help students who are new to wine by offering a clear guide to:

- Learn the names of different grape varieties.
- Understand where important grape varieties are grown around the world.
- Connect grape varieties to specific wine regions and learn about the growing conditions in those areas.
- Explore winemaking techniques used for particular grape varieties and regions.
- Recognize sensory characteristics commonly linked to different grape varieties, such as typical aromas, flavors, and structural elements like sweetness, acidity, tannins, and alcohol.

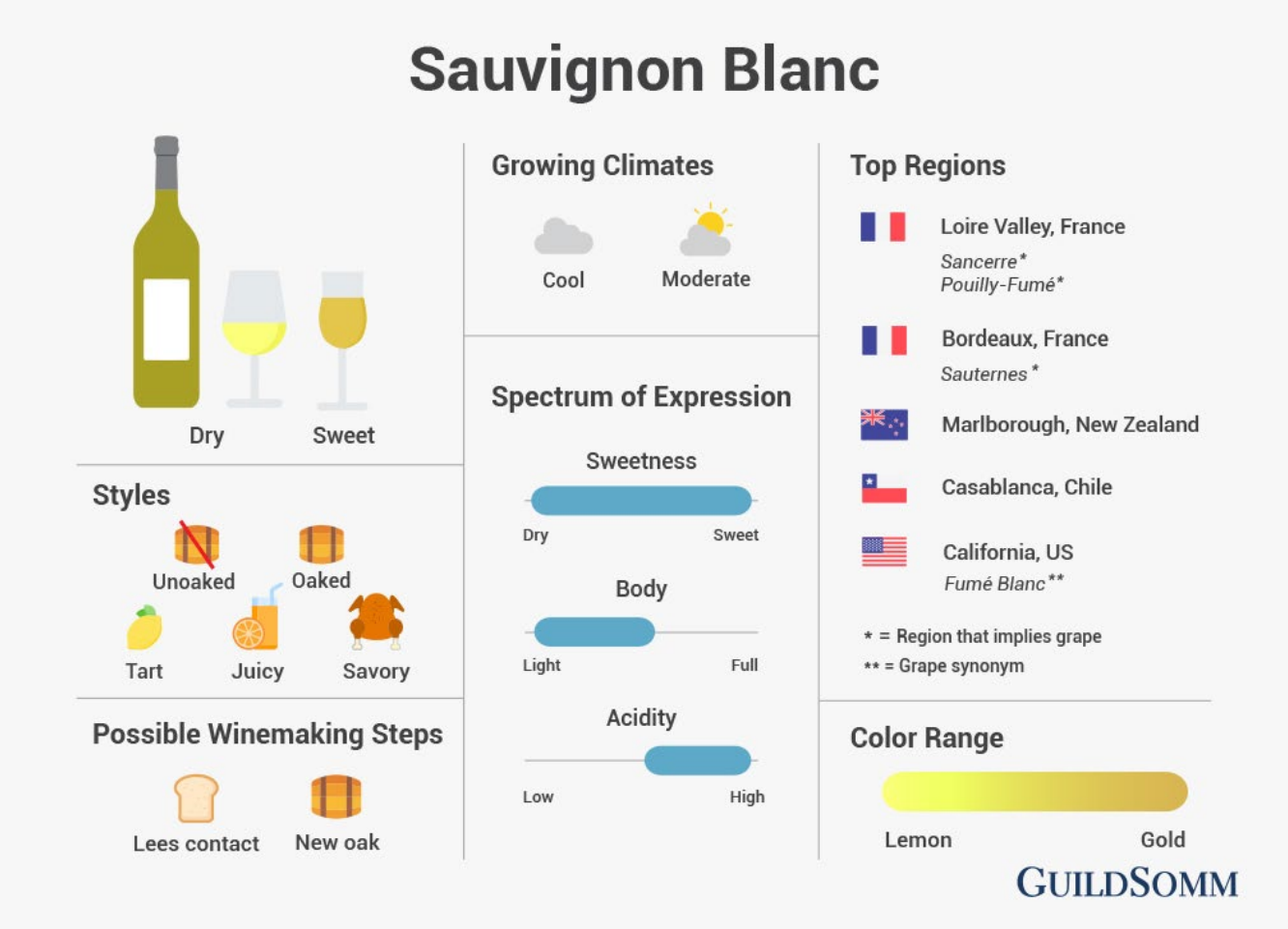
These profiles describe the key traits of each grape variety. For example, knowing that Sauvignon Blanc often has citrusy or grassy flavors helps students build their wine-tasting vocabulary.

These profiles also show the connection between a grape and its region of origin. For instance, understanding that Sangiovese is the main grape in Tuscany, or that Nebbiolo is primarily grown in Piedmont, helps students learn where certain grapes thrive and what types of wines these regions produce.

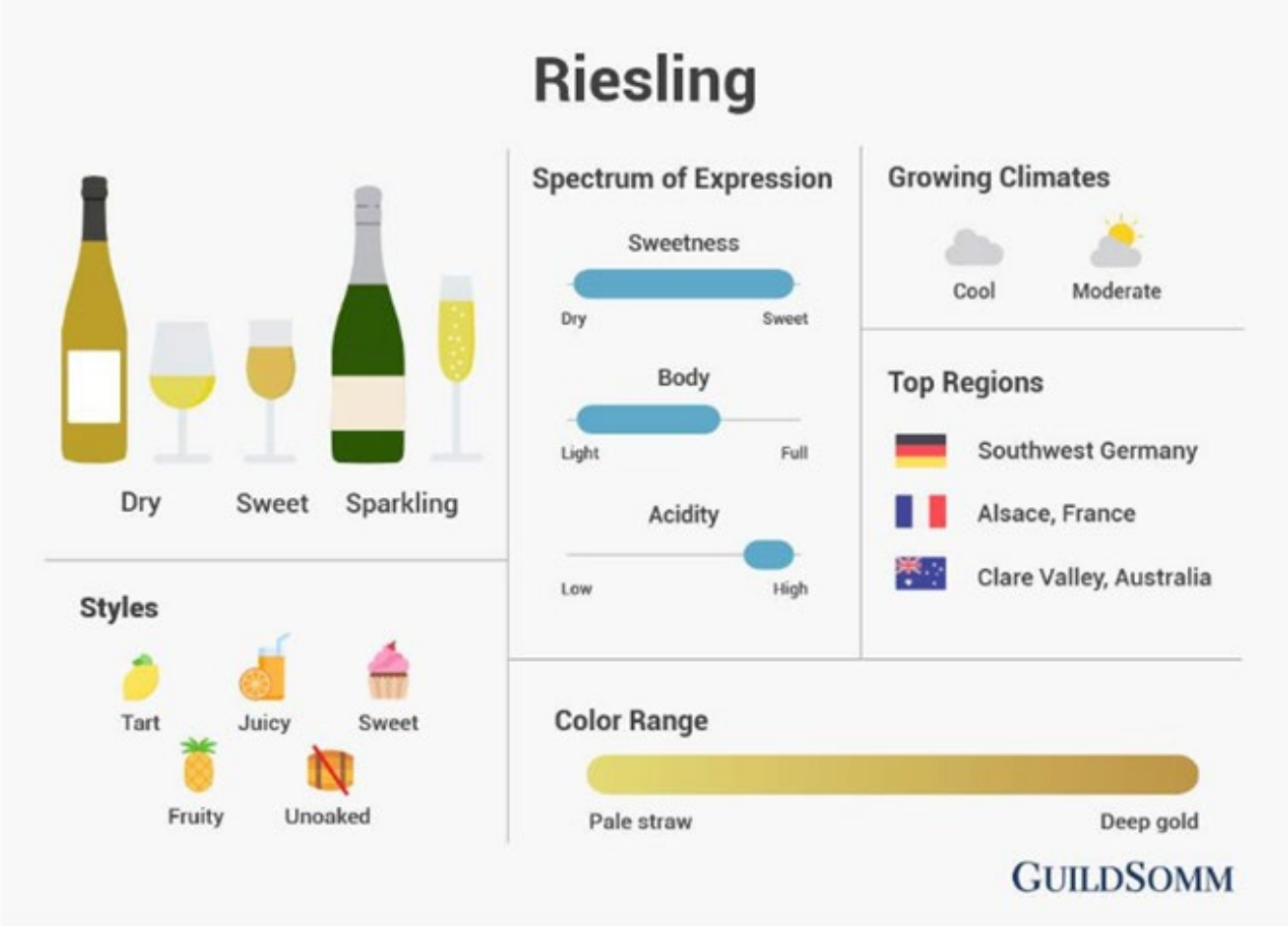
Finally, these profiles provide a framework for wine tasting. By learning the common traits of each grape variety, students can taste wine more confidently and better identify the characteristics in the glass.


Chardonnay
Still
Sparkling
Styles
Decadent
Oaked
Tart
Unoaked
Fruity
Possible Winemaking Steps
Lees contact
Malolactic fermentation
New oak
Growing Climates
Cool
Moderate
Warm
Spectrum of Expression
Sweetness
Dry
Sweet
Body
Light
Full
Acidity
Low
High
Top Regions
Burgundy*, France
Champagne*, France
Blanc de Blancs **
California, US
Oregon, US
Victoria, Australia
* = Region that implies grape
** = Grape synonym
Color Range
Straw
Lemon
Gold
GUILDSOMM

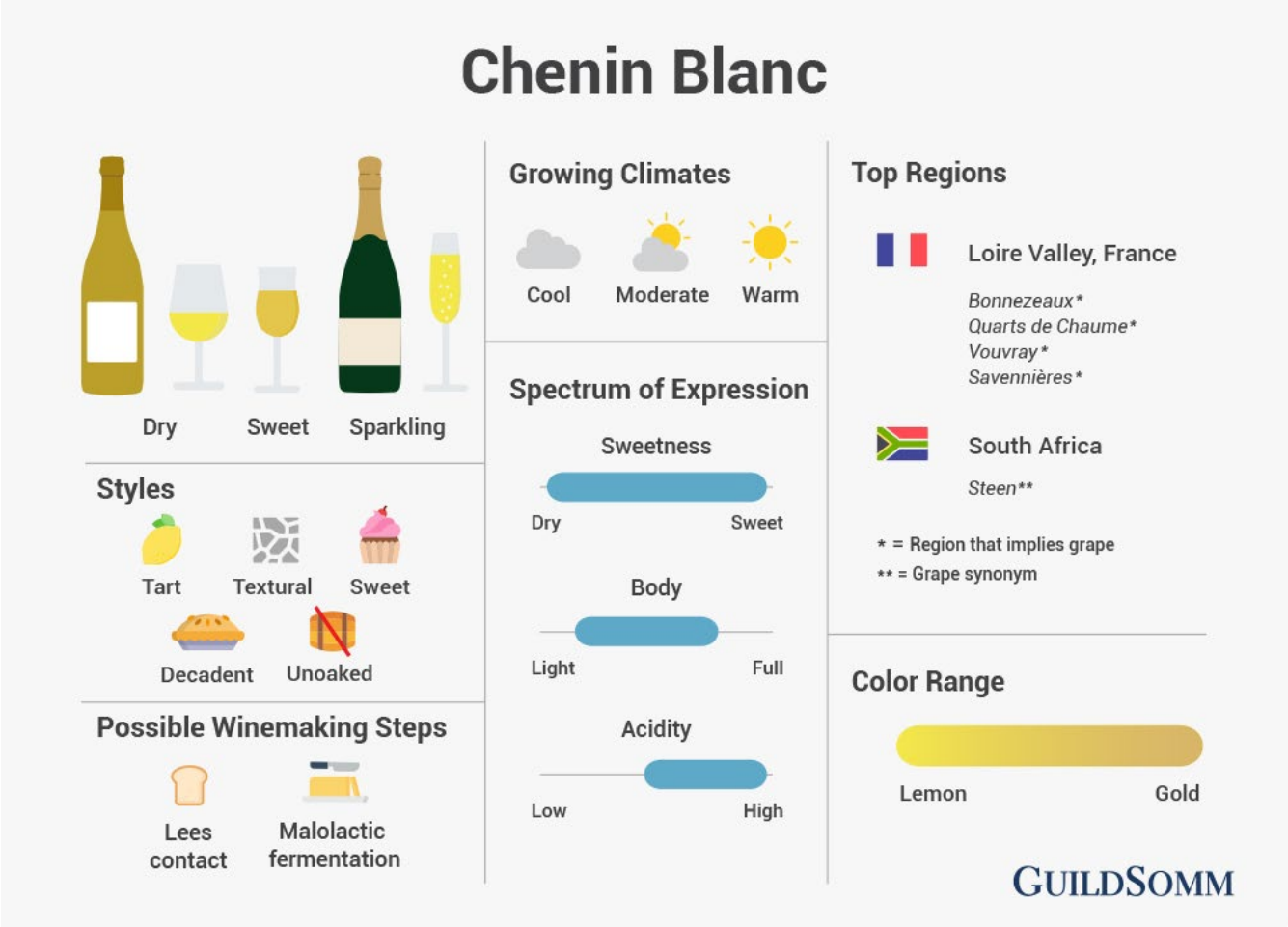
SAUVIGNON BLANC



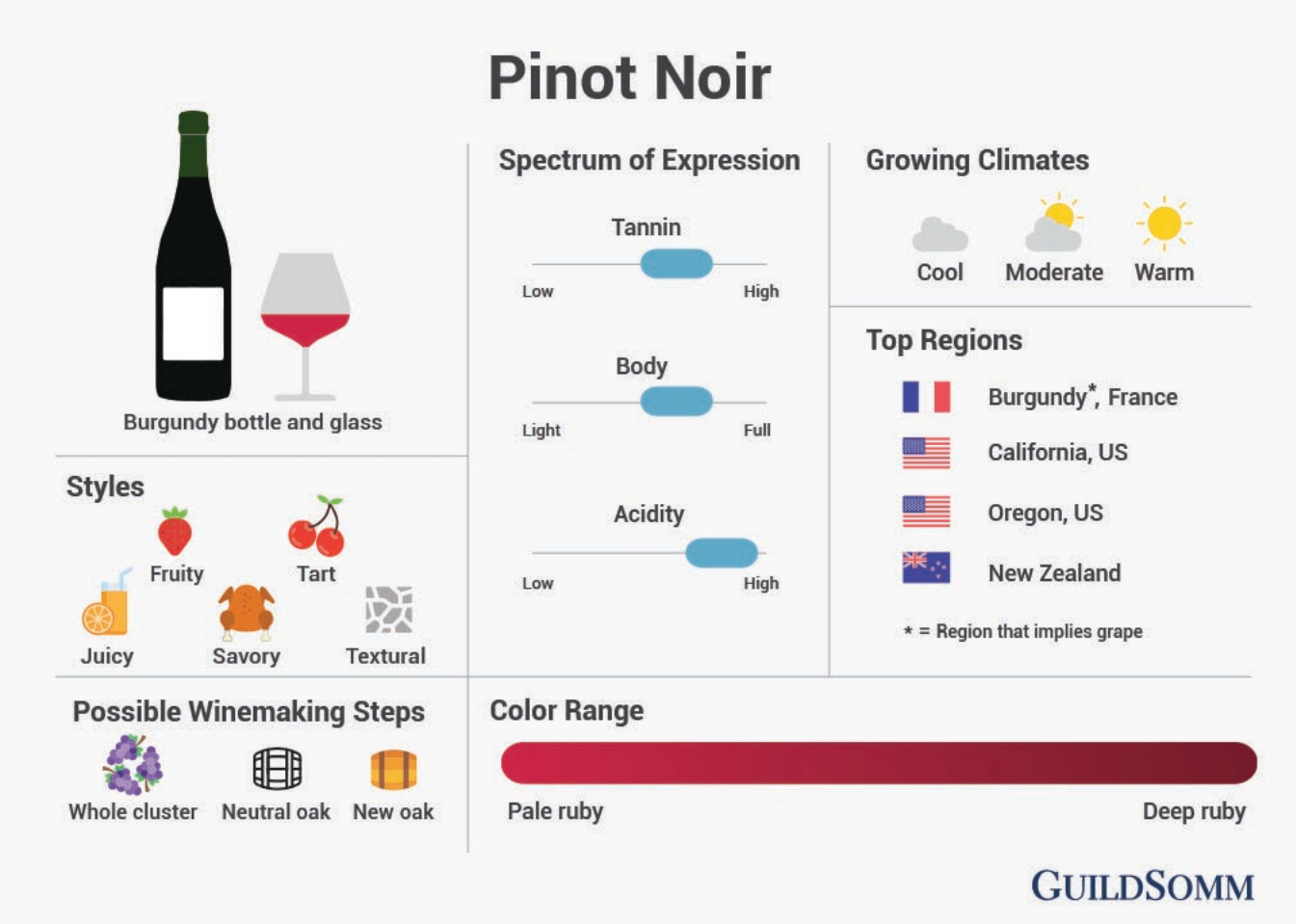
RIESLING


Riesling
Dry
Sweet
Sparkling
Styles
Tart
Juicy
Sweet
Fruity
Unoaked
Spectrum of Expression
Sweetness
Dry
Sweet
Body
Light
Full
Acidity
Low
High
Growing Climates
Cool
Moderate
Top Regions
Southwest Germany
Alsace, France
Clare Valley, Australia
Color Range
Pale straw
Deep gold
GUILDSOMM

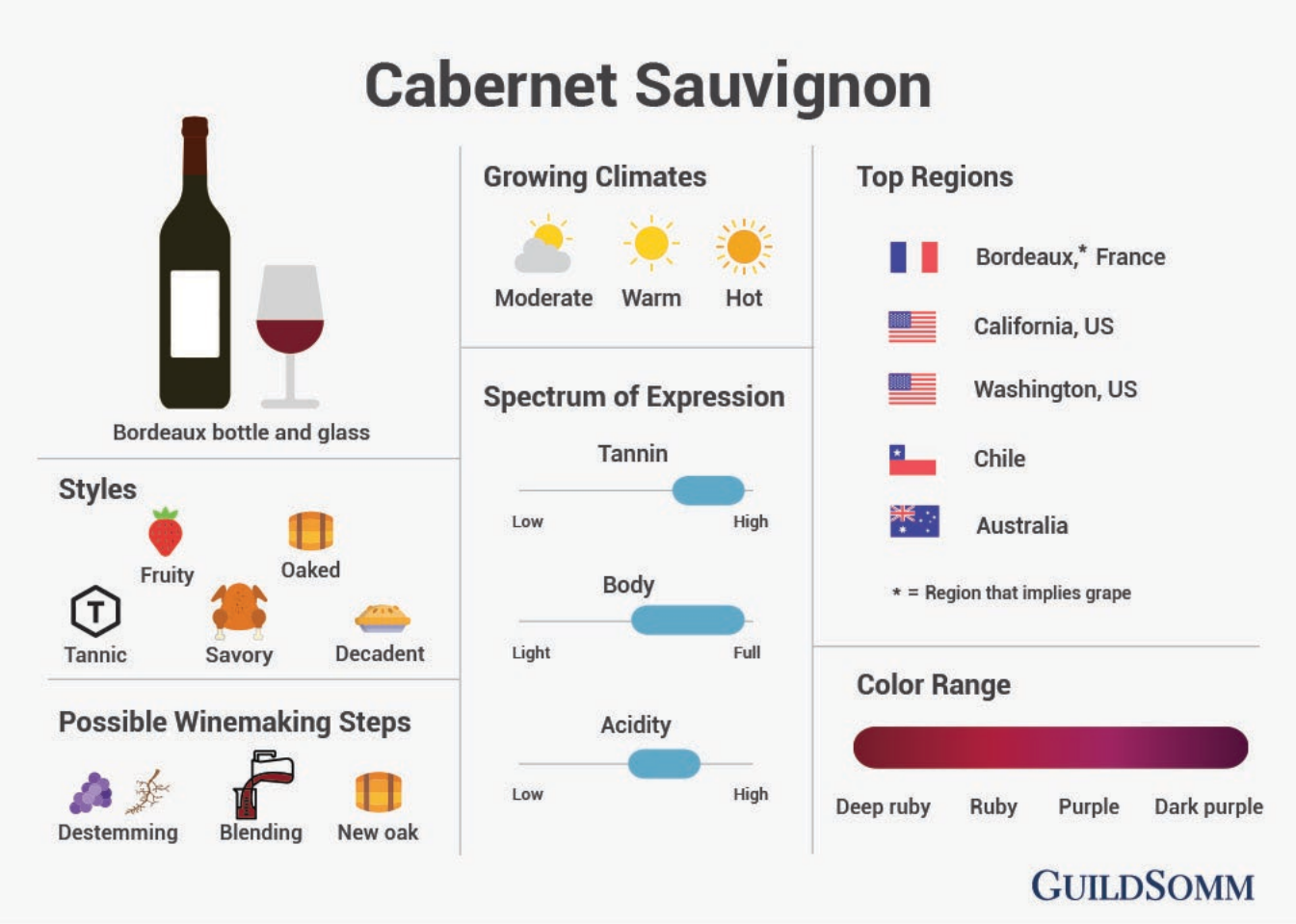
CHENIN BLANC



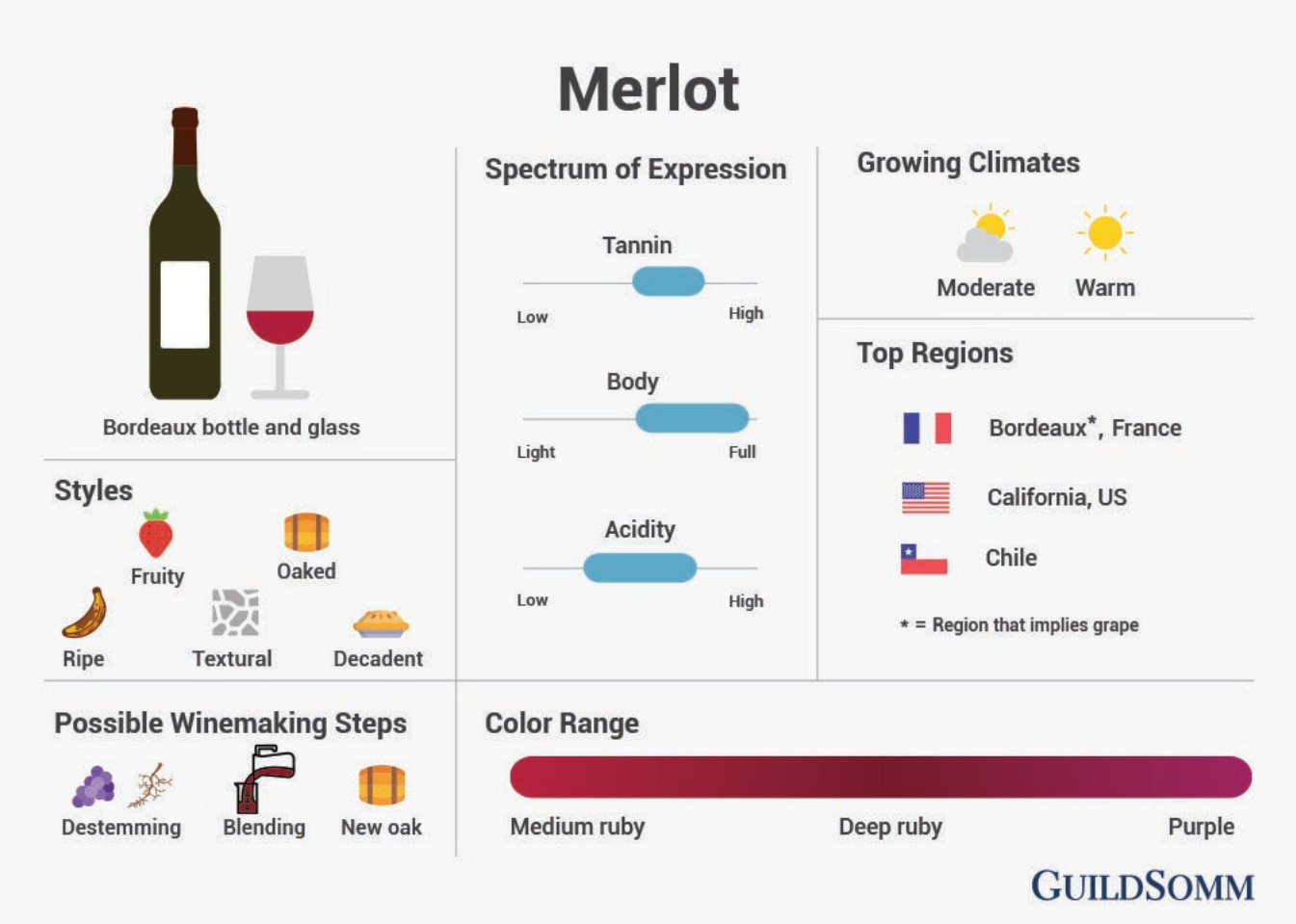
PINOT NOIR


Pinot Noir
Burgundy bottle and glass
Styles
Fruity
Tart
Juicy
Savory
Textural
Possible Winemaking Steps
Whole cluster
Neutral oak
New oak
Spectrum of Expression
Tannin
Low
High
Body
Light
Full
Acidity
Low
High
Growing Climates
Cool
Moderate
Warm
Top Regions
Burgundy*, France
California, US
Oregon, US
New Zealand
* = Region that implies grape
Color Range
Pale ruby
Deep ruby
GUILDSOMM

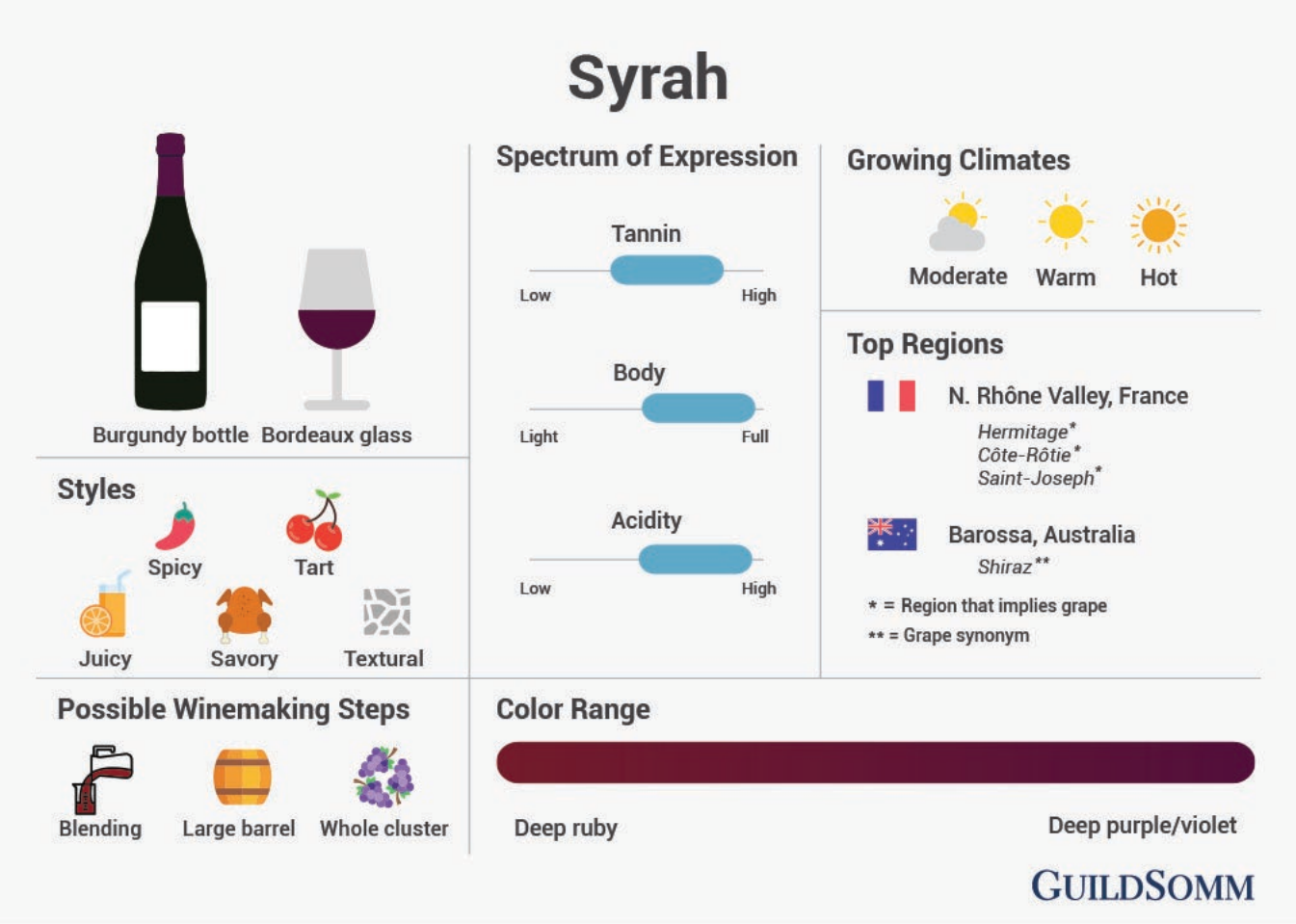
CABERNET SAUVIGNON



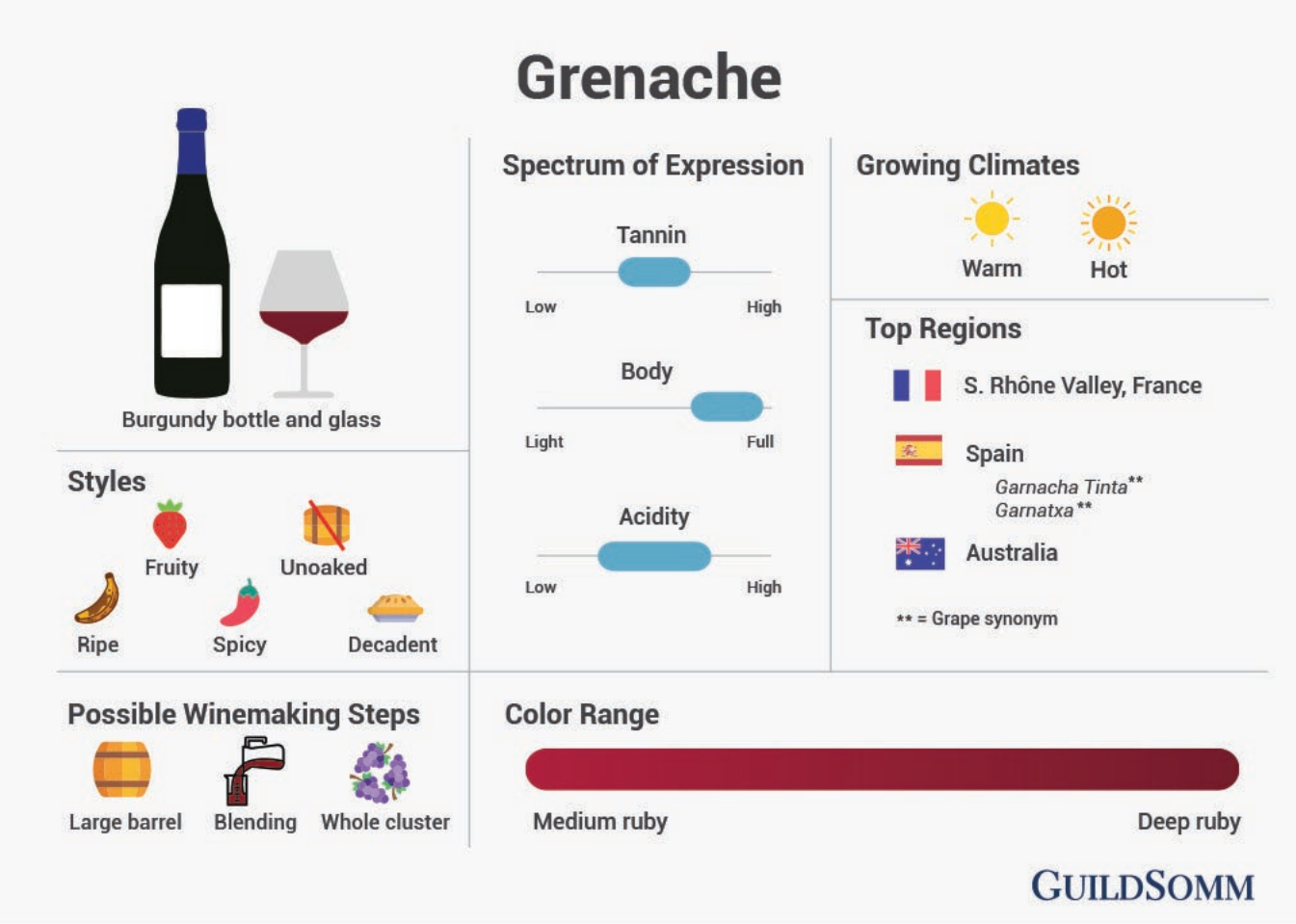
MERLOT


Merlot
Bordeaux bottle and glass
Styles
Fruity
Oaked
Ripe
Textural
Decadent
Spectrum of Expression
Tannin
Low
High
Body
Light
Full
Acidity
Low
High
Growing Climates
Moderate
Warm
Top Regions
Bordeaux*, France
California, US
Chile
* = Region that implies grape
Possible Winemaking Steps
Destemming
Blending
New oak
Color Range
Medium ruby
Deep ruby
Purple
GUILDSOMM

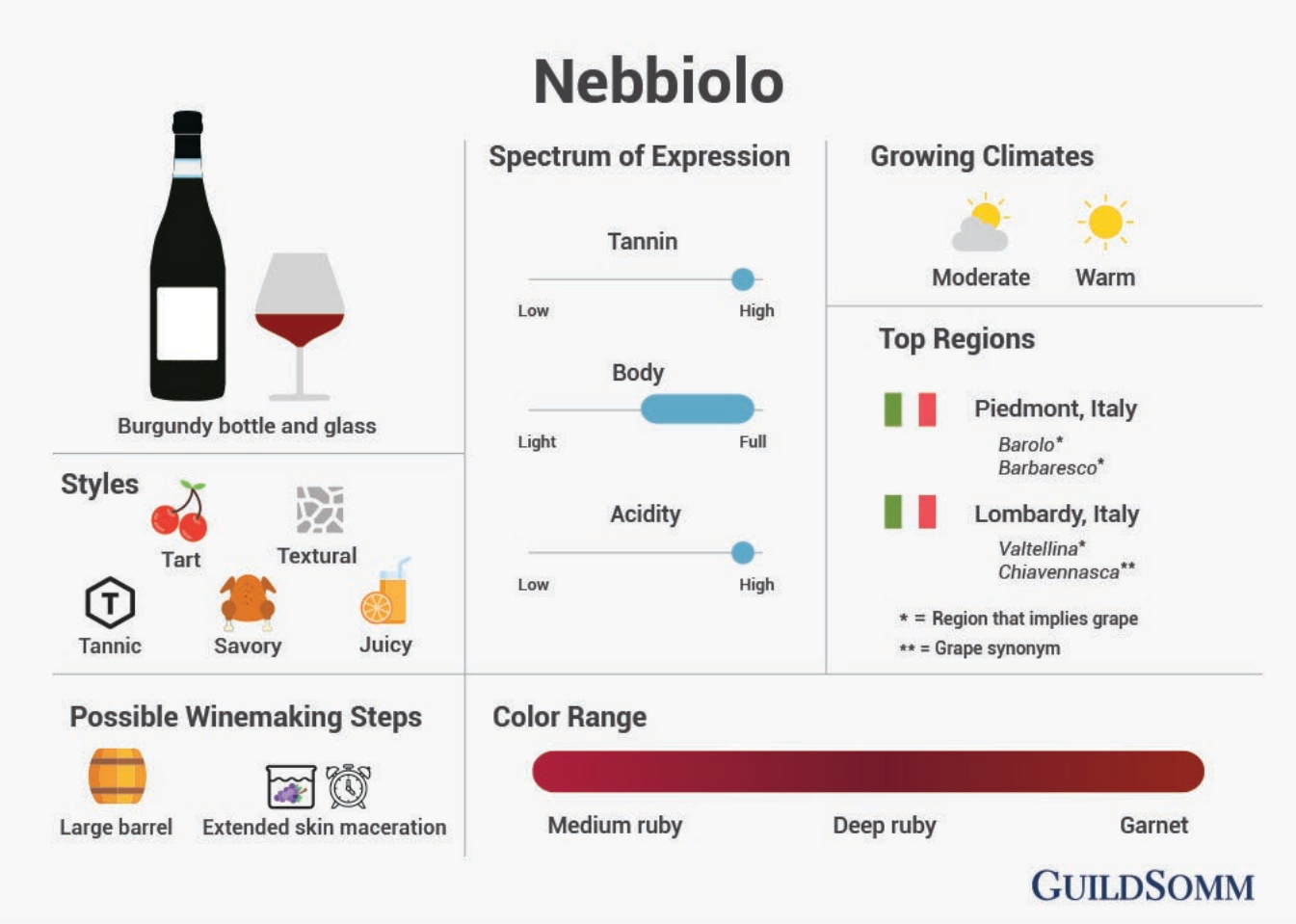
SYRAH


Syrah
Burgundy bottle
Bordeaux glass
Styles
Spicy
Tart
Juicy
Savory
Textural
Possible Winemaking Steps
Blending
Large barrel
Whole cluster
Spectrum of Expression
Tannin
Low
High
Body
Light
Full
Acidity
Low
High
Growing Climates
Moderate
Warm
Hot
Top Regions
N. Rhône Valley, France
Hermitage*
Côte-Rôtie*
Saint-Joseph*
Barossa, Australia
Shiraz**
* = Region that implies grape
** = Grape synonym
Color Range
Deep ruby
Deep purple/violet
GUILDSOMM

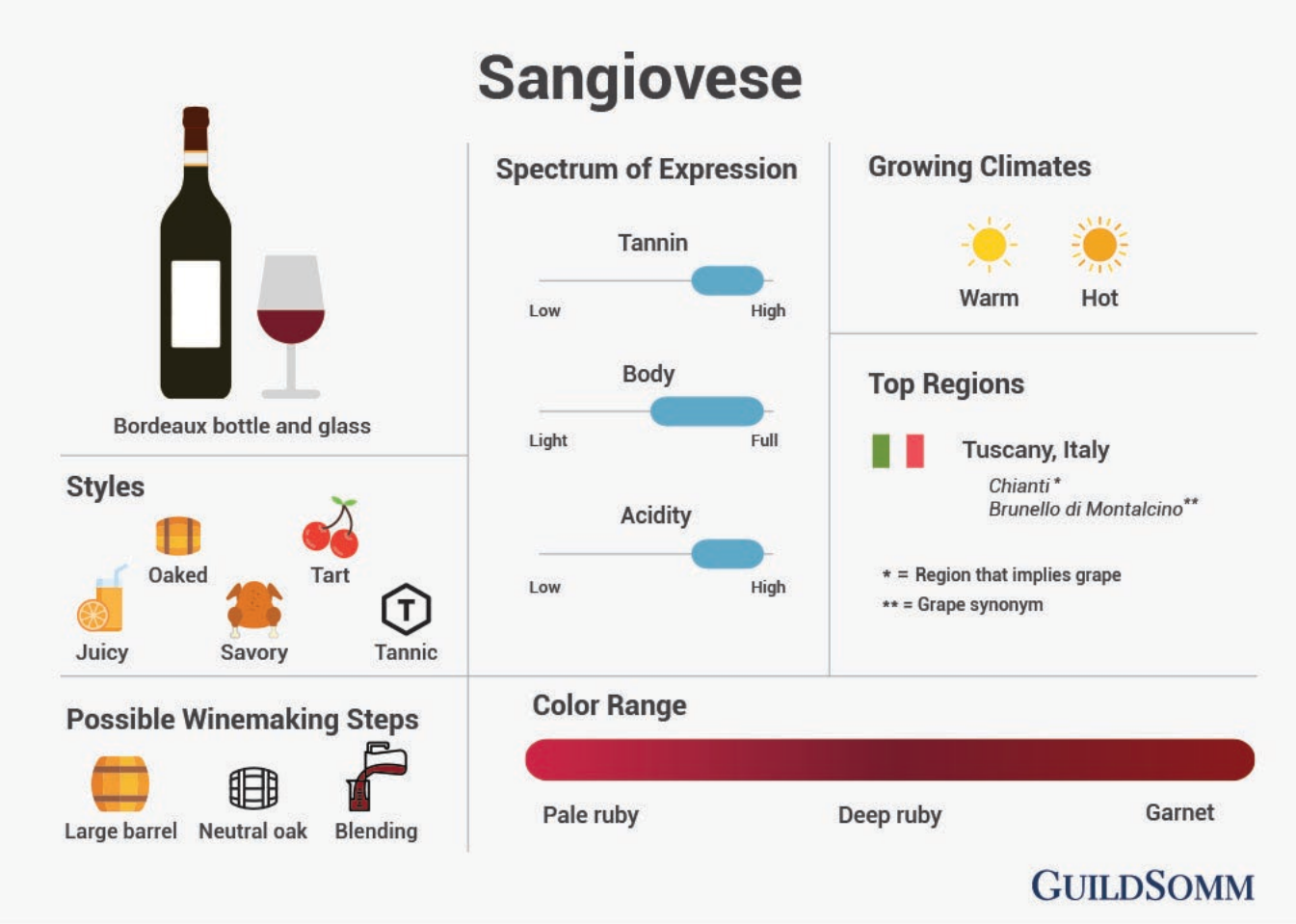
GRENACHE


Grenache
Burgundy bottle and glass
Styles
Fruity
Unoaked
Ripe
Spicy
Decadent
Spectrum of Expression
Tannin
Low
High
Body
Light
Full
Acidity
Low
High
Growing Climates
Warm
Hot
Top Regions
S. Rhône Valley, France
Spain
Garnacha Tinta**
Garnatxa**
Australia
** = Grape synonym
Possible Winemaking Steps
Large barrel
Blending
Whole cluster
Color Range
Medium ruby
Deep ruby
GUILDSOMM

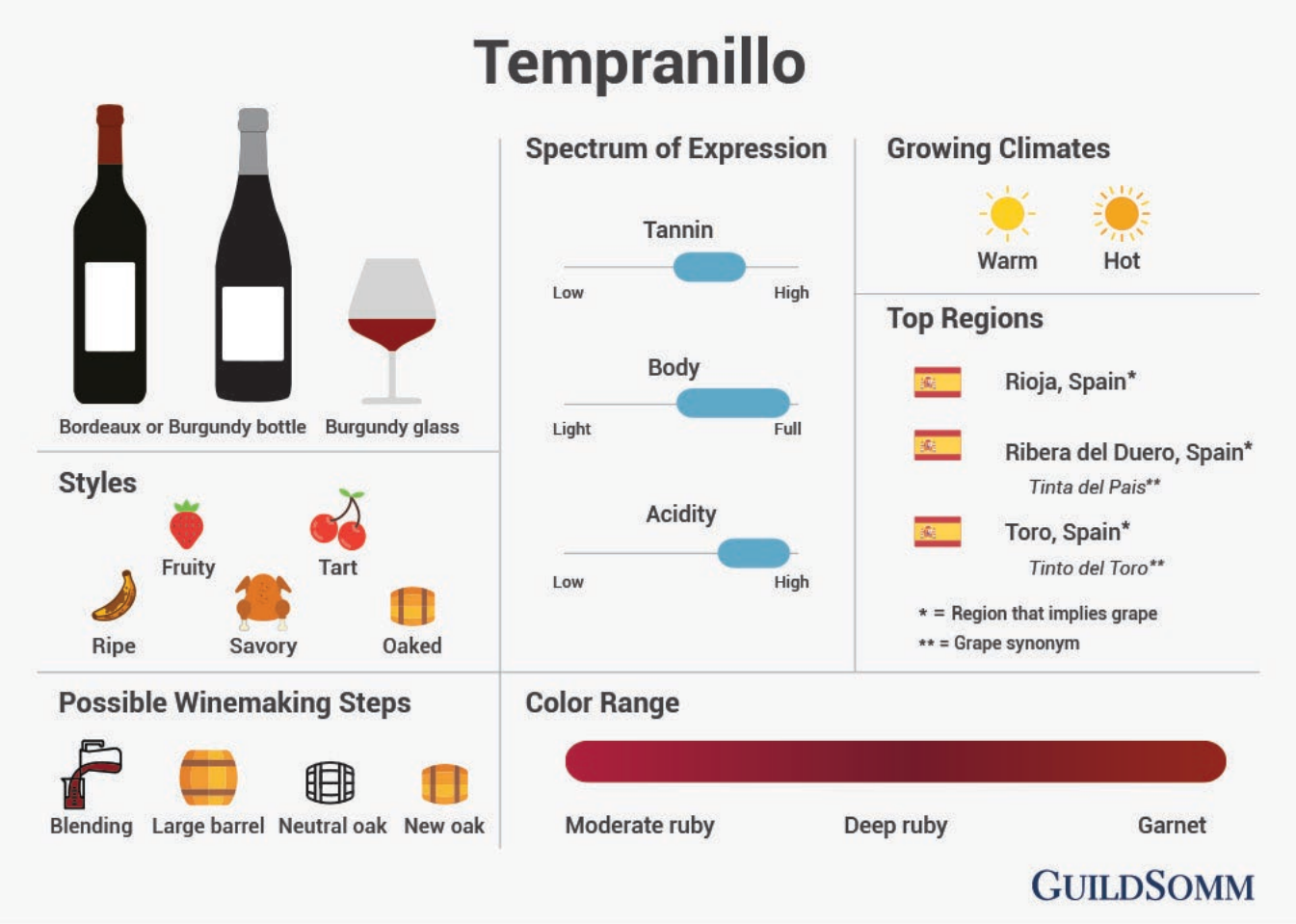
NEBBIOLO


Nebbiolo
Burgundy bottle and glass
Styles
Tart
Textural
Tannic
Savory
Juicy
Spectrum of Expression
Tannin
Low
High
Body
Light
Full
Acidity
Low
High
Growing Climates
Moderate
Warm
Top Regions
Piedmont, Italy
Barolo*
Barbaresco*
Lombardy, Italy
Valtellina*
Chiavennasca**
* = Region that implies grape
** = Grape synonym
Possible Winemaking Steps
Large barrel
Extended skin maceration
Color Range
Medium ruby
Deep ruby
Garnet
GUILDSOMM

SANGIOVESE


Sangiovese
Bordeaux bottle and glass
Styles
Oaked
Tart
Juicy
Savory
Tannic
Spectrum of Expression
Tannin
Low
High
Body
Light
Full
Acidity
Low
High
Growing Climates
Warm
Hot
Top Regions
Tuscany, Italy
Chianti *
Brunello di Montalcino**
* = Region that implies grape
** = Grape synonym
Possible Winemaking Steps
Large barrel
Neutral oak
Blending
Color Range
Pale ruby
Deep ruby
Garnet
GUILDSOMM

TEMPRANILLO



Grape Variety Profiles Courtesy of GuildSomm